

Playbook for guaranteed  
success in product  
assignment rounds

# Product Assignments – playbook

- Outline the user journey & multiple potential goals.
- Identify one focused goal/at max couple based on a clear framework.
- Identify key vectors/axes for generating MVP options and layout MVP options on a  $n \times n$  matrix
- Detail out the MVP product options in one common artifact/table for clear understanding

# Product Assignments – playbook (contd.)

- Set up a clear MVP selection framework
- Plot the different MVP options on the vectors/axes chosen for MVP selection framework and finalize the MVP.
- Outline a GTM & iteration strategy (showcase both product & traffic building experiments)
- Outline clear success metrics & thresholds

# Sample problem statement

Our company (an Ed-Tech company) is looking for ideas that can serve the entire market of students going abroad. The leadership team has debated ideas and the conclusion is to build a knowledge destination for this user segment.

The thesis is that studying abroad is a big decision and students need a lot of guidance/knowledge to make the right decision. Hence, we will build a knowledge destination that will guide students in their study abroad decision making

Your task as a PM is to take this idea forward

Assume that you have full autonomy on all decisions pertaining to this project

Assume that you have 2 developers, 1 UX/UI designers allocated to you

Assume you also have an additional 100K USD for running experiments with the MVP

Assume that we must decide if we want to scale or dump this idea within a month

- What will you build?
- Why this is the right version for this project.
- What experiment will you design to build enough comfort to scale the MVP into a full fledged product

User Segment : 22-28 year old going to study abroad

# KNOWLEDGE BASE FOR INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS



Company Logo

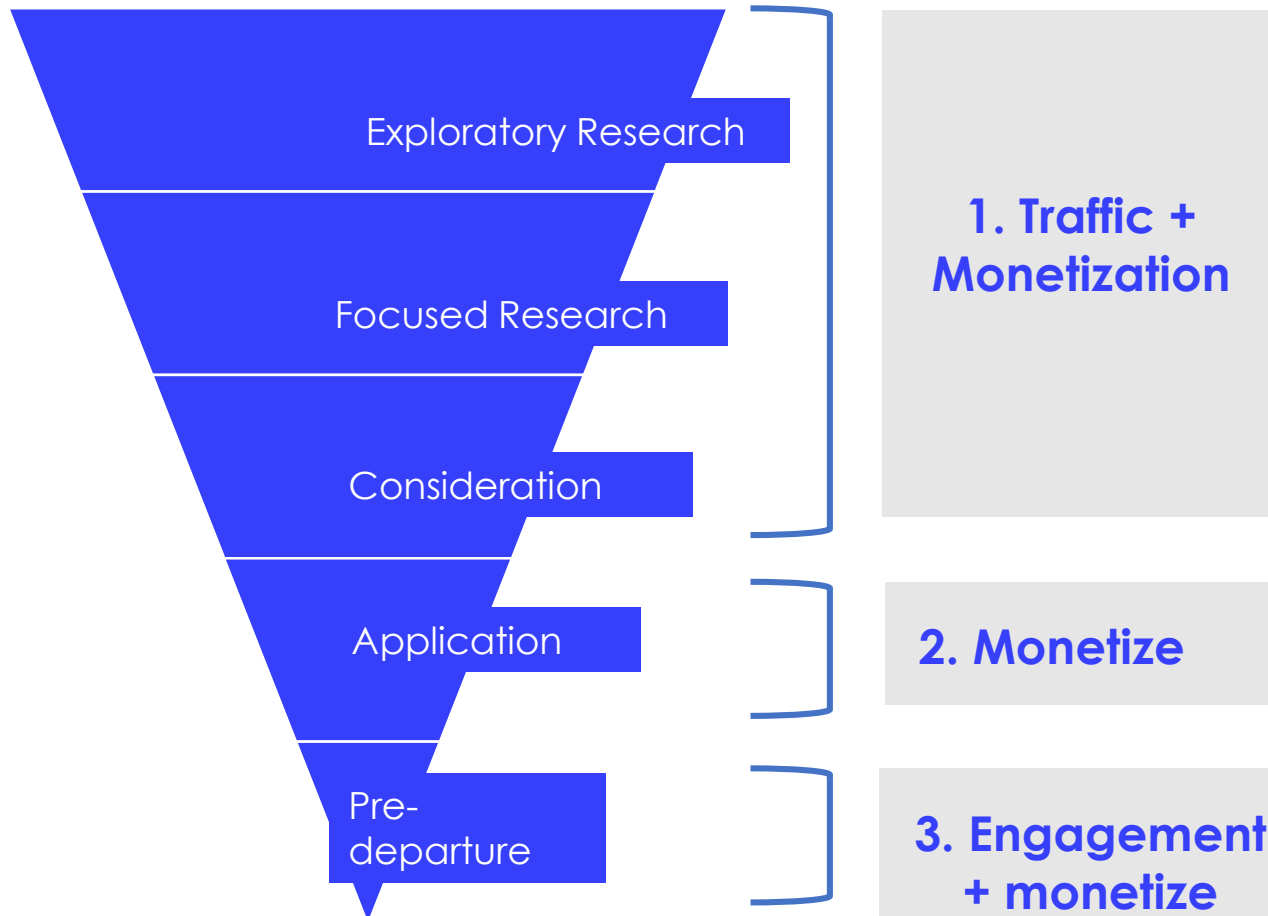
Outline the user journey & multiple potential goals.

# KNOWLEDGE BASE(KB) FOR INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

## User Journey

## Goals we can solve for

## Goal for MVP



**Goal** - Traffic + Nudge towards monetization  
**User phase** - Research + consideration

### Why Traffic goal

**400,000 students** go abroad every year. Assuming a **conversion of 5% (search -> final course start)**, the total potential unique users looking for information on study abroad is 8 M in a year

**The total addressable market is medium size**, and with our KB we **will be new to the market**, it makes sense to focus on the mouth of the funnel to drive traffic and nudge them to later stages of the funnel where we can monetize through newer models or existing products that we have.

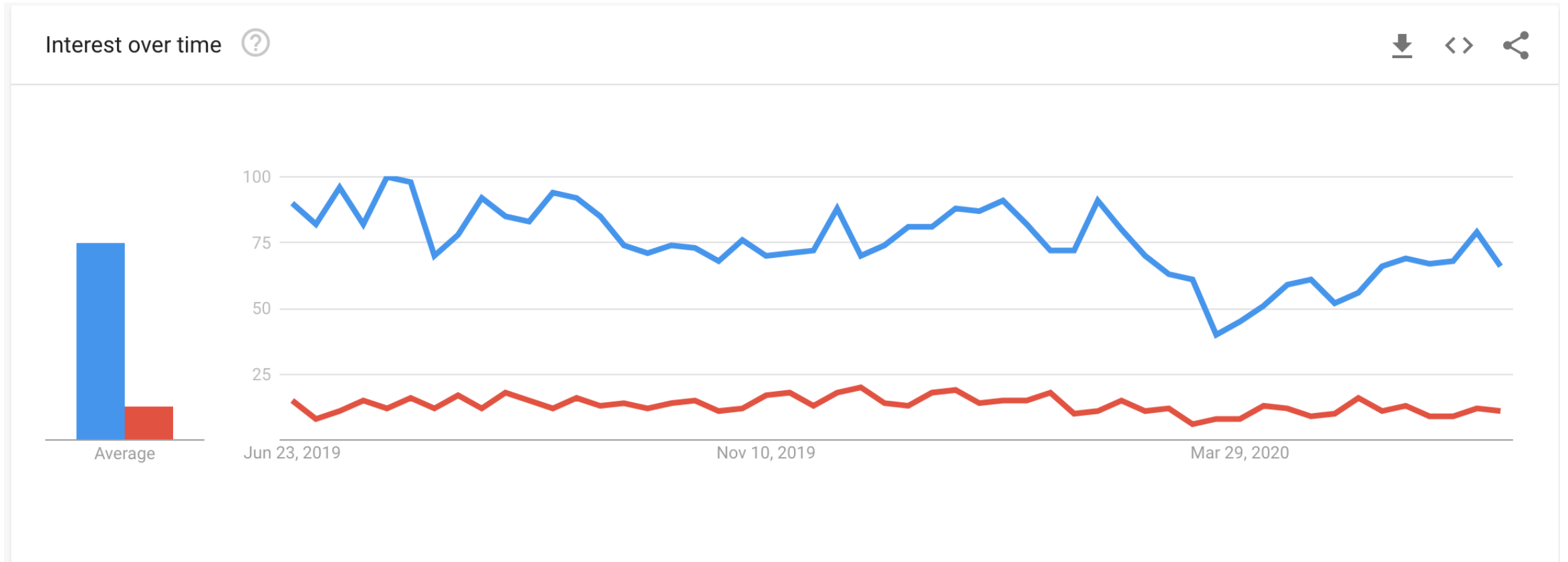
Identify one focused goal/at max  
couple based on a clear  
framework



# WHY RESEARCH PHASE FOR DRIVING TRAFFIC

**6X difference between super top of funnel research kw and slightly focused kw**

Similar scale differences as we go deeper in the funnel



● study abroad  
Search term

● masters in computer science  
Search term

Identify key vectors/axes for  
generating MVP options and  
layout MVP options on a  $n \times n$   
matrix

# PRODUCT OPTIONS FOR MVP

|         |                                                          |                                                                 |                                                     |
|---------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Paywall | Self Serve<br>+ Paywall                                  | Self serve + premium<br>KB Content + DIY<br>tools + Newsletters | Student Assist paid<br>services with tight SLAs     |
| Free    | Complete<br>Self serve KB<br>with a corpus<br>of content | Personalised Self Serve<br>+ newsletter + student<br>community  | Limited period<br>student assist<br>services(trial) |
|         | DIY                                                      | DIY +<br>Personalisation                                        | Managed<br>Serve                                    |



- We want to make sure that we start with an MVP which offers
- a. Value to the user wrt existing alternatives (2-3x better than existing options)
  - b. Builds Trust with the user (they can trust the KB for key information) eventually becoming a one stop destination
  - c. Launch and scaling effort is tightly bound.

Detail out the MVP product options in one common artifact/table

## PRODUCT OPTIONS FOR MVP

| Product Option             | Offering                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DIY + Free                 | Complete self serve with a corpus of content                                                                                                                                                         |
| DIY + Paywall              | Self Serve + Premium KB content behind Paywall                                                                                                                                                       |
| Personalised DIY + Free    | Personalized self serve (eg. Onboarding flow with personalized content)<br>+ topical newsletters                                                                                                     |
| Personalised DIY + Paywall | Personalised self serve + Student community (outside paywall)<br>Premium KB content + DIY tools for personalized treatment – eg. Admission chances + more premium newsletters etc (behind a paywall) |
| Managed serve + Free       | Student Assist by experts – Free version with have some limits (eg. Limited period student assist)                                                                                                   |
| Managed serve + Paywall    | One on one student assist with very tight SLAs (one possible version)                                                                                                                                |

Set up a clear MVP selection  
framework

## MVP SELECTION CRITERIA

### MVP considerations from both internal and user lens

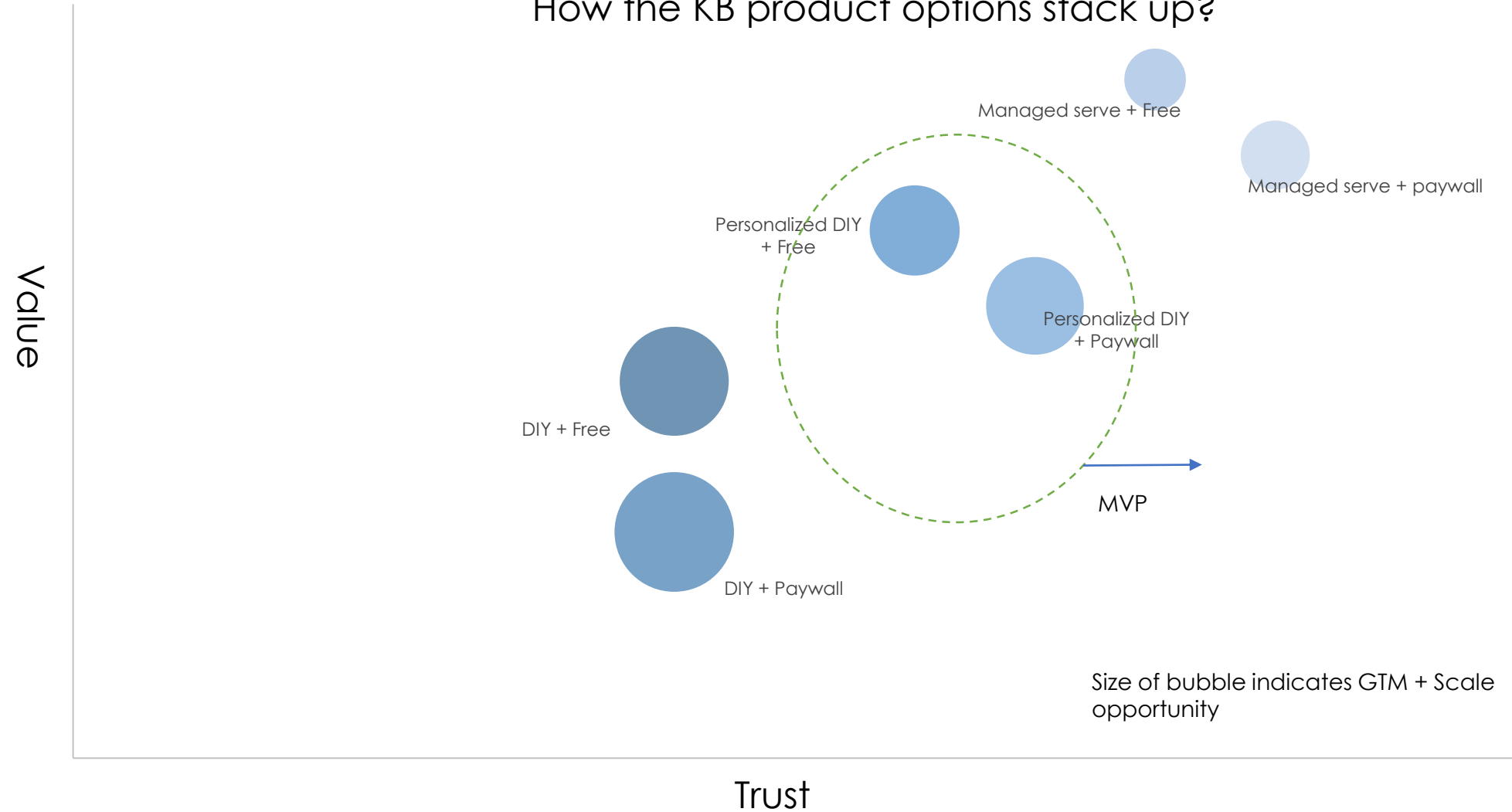
| Internal Lens     | User Lens                                 |                                      |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| GTM & Scale       | Value to user                             | Trust                                |
| 1) Launch Effort  | 1) 2-3x better than existing alternatives | 1) Trust this KB for key information |
| 2) Scaling Effort |                                           | 2) One stop destination              |

Plot the MVP options on the  
vectors/axes chosen and finalize  
the MVP



# CHOOSING THE MVP

How the KB product options stack up?



Outline a GTM & iteration strategy  
(showcase both product & traffic  
building experiments)

## 1 MONTH EXPERIMENT(Budget 100k)

Following are some of the experiments

| Product Experiment            | Explainer                                                                      | Budget |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| 1. Teaser video content       | Adcom interviews, success stories video format                                 | \$15K  |
| 2. Incentivized leader board  | Leaderboard for contribution to student community (Top contributors get \$X)   | \$10K  |
| 3. Social sharing experiments | Tiered Incent for sharing - \$X for 5 signups + milestone event for anti abuse | \$10K  |
| 4. Monetization experiments   | Paywall experiment (time based/premium products)                               | NA     |

| Mktng Experiment                    | Explainer                                         | Budget                   |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| 1. Online Traffic campaigns         | Run ads on Search, YouTube, Social                | \$50K (Target CPM = \$3) |
| 2. Offline campaigns + user testing | Promotion in campuses -doubles up as user testing | \$15K                    |

Outline clear success metrics &  
thresholds

## KEY METRICS DEFINITION FOR MVP SUCCESS

Following are the key metrics that we will be tracking to measure the success of MVP

| Key Metrics              | Metrics Benchmarks                                                                                  |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Unique Users          | <b>20-30K sign ups</b><br>\$50k mkt spend at avg of \$3 CPM, 2% CTR, 10% conv                       |
| 2. Subscription Sign ups | <b>4K subscription sign ups (Milestone event indicates product efficacy)</b><br>20% of 20K sign ups |
| 3. Repeat rate           | <b>7 day repeat rate</b><br>Should be high – 30%+                                                   |
| 4. Product NPS           | <b>20+ score (This is a fairly high NPS for B2C products)</b><br>On NPS surveys                     |

Also metrics from some of the other experiments such as Incent leader board, video content, monetization need to be evaluated for future scale-up of the MVP

# Bonus points

- Add a wireframe if you can.
- Add a scaling plan post MVP success.

# DIY PERSONALIZED RECOMMENDATIONS

A Web Page

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These recommendations are basis match rates based on data points

| Courses                                     | Chances of selection | Avg GRE score | Top employers                | Typical median salaries |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|---------------|------------------------------|-------------------------|
| <a href="#">MS in Computer Science/ MIT</a> | 45%/ Stretch Target  | 330           | Google, Facebook,Amazon      | \$300K/year             |
| <a href="#">MS in Computer Science/ CMU</a> | 85%/ Good chances    | 325           | Apple, Netflix, Google       | \$300K/year             |
| <a href="#">Course3/ University</a>         | 70%/ Safe target     | 320           | Microsoft, Adobe, Salesforce | \$250K/year             |
| <a href="#">Course4/ University</a>         | XXXXXXX              | XX            | XXXXX, XXXX                  | \$XXX/year              |
| <a href="#">Course5/ University</a>         | XXXXXXX              | XX            | XXXX, XXXX, XXXX             | \$XXX/year              |

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# SCALING PLAN

## Scaling plans

| Themes                                      | Ideas                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Managed Serve (Super personalized)          | Student Assist at different stages in the funnel (shortlisting, application, Pre-departure) |
| Premium content + events                    | Live AMAs (successful candidates, Adcom), In person meetups                                 |
| Beefed up pre-departure + post departure KB | Eg. Settling in guides, KB on internship opportunities, part time work opportunities,       |
| Other distribution channels + growth ideas  | YouTube SEO, Podcasts (eg. on Spotify), Reddit channels, Twitter Threads, etc               |

**THANK YOU**

